their memories of past coexistence.[9] To say that people highlighted past coexistence is not to say that there has never been anti-Muslim sentiment in Myanmar, or that Muslims have not been subject to violence at other times. Instead, it means that, for many of the people we spoke to, articulating a sense of prior coexistence entailed doing subsequent interpretive work to reconcile this contradiction:

> Before I joined this association [MaBaTha], I felt that we are all the same human beings in my heart … There was no discrimination in my mind. Not only I felt this way, all Buddhists have this same feeling. But after the [riots in May 2013] took place, I knew that the situation was not the same any more … This is the weakness [of Buddhists], we don't know what [Muslims] are doing to our religion, or making our religion shrink. I didn't notice this, but when I studied about it in detail, I found out that it's a dangerous issue. So we have to find ways to protect our religion.[10]

Ultimately, our purpose was not to conduct a poll; the point in that M.MAS project research — and this chapter — is to understand how those who express a sense of antagonism towards Islam understand and justify such a sense, not to determine the percentage of the Myanmar population who feel a certain way. By asking people to articulate their concerns, the interview encounter encouraged them to make arguments — and indeed, some of the narrators we listened to approached the encounter as an opportunity to try and persuade us into agreement.

We identified a narrative consistent with our earlier research and with the rhetoric of groups like MaBaTha and 969, which we loosely grouped into two interrelated conceptions of threat. First, Muslims were presented as an existential threat to race and religion. This was the idea that Buddhism or a particular ethnic community in Myanmar was vulnerable, and at real risk of being lost forever. Second, Muslims were depicted as a personal threat, to the narrator or their community of residence. The source of this threat was consistently defined in *religious* terms. Individuals identified the object of their fear using terminology both religious (Islam and Muslim) and racial (*kalar*[11] and Bengali). But the arguments we heard rested on a fundamentally religious premise: that Islam is unitary and that it is violent, threatening, and otherwise inferior to Buddhism. This argument about Islam was made as a general, universalized claim. It was also connected to specific religious practices that were highlighted as both objectionable and allegedly intrinsic to Islamic tradition, such as the butchering of cows or mistreatment of women.